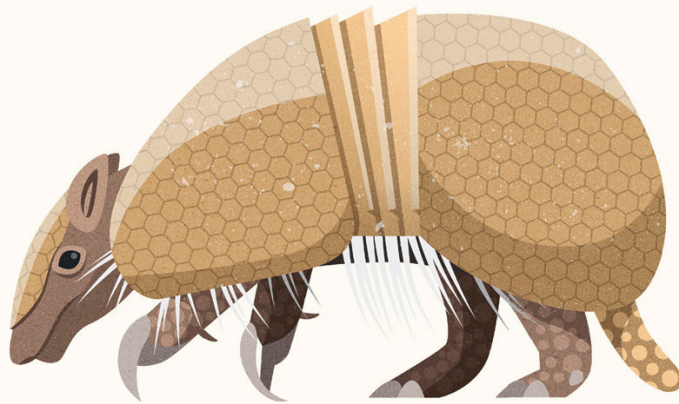


The smallest species of armadillo is the pink fairy armadillo. It is only about half the length of a pencil.

Armadillo



At first it might look like an oddly-shaped football, but if you get closer you will see this is the honeycomb-like shell of a three-banded armadillo. If a jaguar or bird of prey tries to attack, it rolls into a tight ball. The Brazilian three-banded armadillo is one of only two armadillos that can roll into a perfect sphere. The three narrow bands around its middle help its bony shell to bend. When it senses the danger is gone, the animal uncurls and trots off to find food or to sleep. Armadillos often sleep 16 hours a day! Although they have a heavy shell, some armadillos are remarkably good swimmers. They swallow air to help them float as they paddle.